Samudragupta introduced the Gupta monetary system. Kushana coins provided inspiration to Samudragupta. The Gupta gold coins were known as *Dinara*. Guptas issued many gold coins but comparatively fewer silver and copper coins. However, the post-Gupta period saw a fall in the circulation of gold coins, indicating the decline in the prosperity of the empire.

Metallurgy

- Mining and metallurgy were the most flourishing industries during the Gupta period.
- The most important evidence of development in metallurgy was the Mehrauli Iron Pillar installed by King Chandragupta in Delhi. This monolithic iron pillar has lasted through the centuries without rusting.

The metals used by them were: iron, gold, copper, tin, lead, brass, bronze, bell- metal, mica, manganese and red chalk.



Mehrauli Iron Pillar

Society

The society that adhered to four *varna* system was patriarchal. According to laws of Manu, which was in force, women should be under the protection of their father, husband or eldest son. Polygamy was widely prevalent. The kings and feudatory lords often had more than one wife. Inscriptions refer to Kubernaga and Dhrubaswamini as the queens of Chandragupta II. Sati was practised during the Gupta rule.

Slavery

Slavery was not institutionalised in India, as in the West. But there are references to the existence of various categories of slaves during the Gupta age.

Religion

There was revival of Vedic religion and Vedic rites. Samudragupta and Kumaragupta I performed *Asvamedha* Yagna (a horse sacrifice ritual). We notice the beginning of image worship and the emergence of two sects, namely Vaishnavism and Saivism, during the Gupta period. Buddhism also continued to flourish though it split into two sects, namely Hinayana and Mahayana.

Art and Architecture

The Guptas were the first to construct temples, which evolved from the earlier tradition of rock-cut shrines. Adorned with towers and elaborate carvings, these temples were dedicated to all Hindu deities.

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